understanding and the breadth of their views, fully comprehended both realms of thought'. Akbar also asked Bhanuchandra Suri to teach him the Suryasahasranama, or the 1,000 names to worship the sun god. In Bhanuchandra's commentary, Akbar approached the monk and asked him: 'Tell me who among good people can teach me this?' The Jains replied, 'only one who has subdued all the senses, sleeps on the ground, and possesses sacred knowledge is qualified in this manner. When he heard this, the Shah (Akbar) said, "Only you (Bhanuchandra) possess such qualities here. You alone, venerable one, will teach me this every morning."' Akbar learnt the 1,000 names, we are told, and would stand facing the east, with folded hands pressed to his forehead, and concentrate his mind on the effulgence of the rising sun.

Sun worship was a potent symbol for Akbar, as it was venerated by many people at court and across the country. Hindus worshipped the sun while reciting the Gayatri Mantra and Raja Birbal himself was a believer in sun worship. The Parsees, some of the Sufis, the Rajputs at court, Akbar's Rajput wives, and the Timurids, would all recognize the power and visible symbolism of the Padshah venerating the sun.

While Akbar worshipped the sublime light of dawn, along with the cerebral, philosophical, and austere Jain monks, he also acquainted himself with more tenebrous ascetics, adept at the mysteries of the night. 'His Majesty also called some of the Jogis,' wrote Badauni, 'and gave them at night…interviews.' Akbar would question the jogis about their methods of meditation, spiritual practices, postures, alchemical preparations, and practice of magical powers. On Shivratri, Akbar joined this ferocious, unfettered group of men in the opaque night and ate and drank with them. The worship of Bhairava, the most terrible aspect of Shiva, was said to be 'both intemperate and licentious'. On this bleak and black night, the Shivlinga was worshipped every third hour with offerings of flowers, dhatura, ketaki, and bel leaves and it was bathed, in succession, with milk, curd, ghee and honey, and Gangajal. The jogis predicted the Padshah would live three or four times as long as ordinary men. 'Fawning court doctors,' sneered Badauni, 'wisely enough, found proofs for the longevity of the Emperor'. On being told that there were hermits and recluses living in Tibet and Mongolia, who could live for more than 200 years, Akbar began practising increasing austerity in his life and habits. He 'limited the time he spent in the harem', wrote Badauni, and 'curtailed his food and drink, but